"WAR ON TERROR'

## INVASION OF IRAQ



**Date** March 20–April 11, 2003
**Forces** Americans: 115 ships; British: 22 ships; Iraqis: unknown
**Losses** Coalition forces: unknown; Iraqis: unknown

**Location** Persian Gulf, Red Sea, and Iraq

In many ways the invasion of Iraq in 2003 was very different than the war conducted against Saddam Hussein's forces in 1991. Instead of repeating the first Gulf War's prolonged air campaign as preparation for the ground assault, the second war against Iraq saw a near simultaneous launch of air and ground assets, with land forces making a direct, fast strike toward the Iraqi capital Baghdad. Nonetheless, as with the 1991 conflict, it was the US Navy that fired the opening shots.

At 5:15 a.m. on March 20, 2003, the Ticonderoga-class destroyer USS *Bunker Hill* fired the first of many US Navy Tomahawk missiles targeted at command-and-control centers and political targets deep in Iraq. Shortly afterward, US and UK ground forces attacked Iraq from across the Kuwaiti border. The US forces, with a large Marine Corps spearhead, would strike up to Baghdad, while British troops took responsibility for securing Basra, Iraq's second city.

### SHOCK AND AWE

The order of battle of the coalition's naval contingent was formidable. The US Navy element alone (by far the biggest portion) ran to 115 ships, including five carrier battle groups centered around the carriers *Kitty Hawk*, *Constellation*, *Theodore Roosevelt*, *Abraham Lincoln,* and *Harry S. Truman*. The aviation striking power of these carrier groups was truly enormous, and F-18 Hornets, F-14 Tomcats, and US Marine Corps AV-8B Harriers provided close-air support for the advancing troops. The *Constellation* carrier group alone flew more than 1,500 sorties during Operation Iraqi Freedom – as the US operations were codenamed – during which it dropped more than 1 million lb (450,000 kg) of ordnance. Tomahawk-armed destroyers within the group (including *Bunker Hill*) fired a total of 408 cruise missiles.

### SUPPORT MISSIONS

Allied warships also provided offshore gunnery platforms for missions on land. For example, the Royal Navy warships HMS *Richmond*, *Marlborough*, and *Chatham,* and HMAS *Anzac* delivered bombardments in support of British Royal Marine and USMC assaults on the Al-Faw peninsula, a critical southern action that included the capture of Umm Qasr, the only deep-water port in Iraq.

Baghdad was finally secured in the first week of April 2003, after what appeared to be a vigorously successful operation. The post-invasion conflict, however, far exceeded the worst expectations in terms of fighting, and US Marine and Navy air assets remain on call to deliver strikes in support of counter-insurgency operations.

**US Carrier Strike Group**
Nuclear-powered supercarrier *George Washington* is accompanied by ships from her strike group during their deployment in the Gulf in support of Operation Iraqi Freedom in June 2004.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

## SHIP-LAUNCHED CRUISE MISSILES

The development of cruise missiles that track to a target in a sustained, guided flight pattern began during World War II on both sides of the Allied-Axis divide, but was refined to operational level during the postwar period. The Regulus was the first US ship-launched version. It had a range of 575 miles (926 km) and could be launched from both submarines and surface vessels. Regulus was deployed between 1955 and 1964. In the 1970s and 80s the world caught up with US advances and a wide range of ship-launched cruise missiles emerged in other world navies, such as the SS-N-12 (USSR) and the HY-2 Haiyang (China). The most famous of all the cruise missiles, however, remains the Tomahawk, used to powerful effect during both the 1991 and 2003 Persian Gulf Wars. Based on this success, new generations of long-range cruise missiles have recently entered service with many navies, including Pakistan, India, France, and Russia.

**Tomahawk cruise missile**
A subsonic Tomahawk missile is fired from an armored box launcher during Operation Desert Storm.




**Regulus cruise missile**
The turbojet-powered supersonic Regulus was the US Navy's main strategic nuclear deterrent during the early days of the Cold War.